

and allergic conditions affecting the eyes, middle ear, sinuses, and nasal passages. Eyebright counters liquid mucus, but it should be used guardedly for dry and stuffy congestion, which tends to be made worse by the plant's astringency.

Self-help Uses Allergic rhinitis with mucus, p. 300; Conjunctivitis, p. 310; Prevention of nosebleeds, p. 310.



Eyebright, as its name suggests, helps eye problems.

Euterpe oleracea (Arecaceae) Acai

Description A rainforest palm reaching 80 ft (25 m), with 4–8 slender trunks and pinnate leaves up to 10 ft (3 m) long. The berries (about the size of a grape) hang down in large bunches.

Habitat & Cultivation Found throughout much of Central America and northern South America, the acai palm is widely grown for its berries and palm hearts.

Parts Used Drupe (the “berries”), seed, root, palm heart.

Constituents The berries contain high levels of polyphenols, especially anthocyanins and proanthocyanidins (as found in other dark purple berries, such as blueberry). They are strong antioxidants and anti-inflammatories.

History & Folklore Acai berries and their juice are a nutritious part of many Brazilians' diet. In Brazil and Peru, the crushed seeds (which make up 80% of the berry) are used to treat fever. Traditionally, the essence of the root is extracted to treat conditions such as hepatitis and enlarged prostate.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Less a medicine than a nourishing addition to the diet, acai supports vitality and a healthy heart and circulation. Acai juice has much in common with blueberry and pomegranate (*Punica granatum*, p. 259) juices—all helping to sustain good health. The Acai palm is the main source of palm hearts, which are eaten worldwide as a vegetable.

Evodia rutaecarpa (Rutaceae) Evodia, Wu Zhu Yu (Chinese)

Description Deciduous tree growing to 33 ft (10 m). Has compound leaves, clusters of white flowers, and greenish-red fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to China, Tibet, and the eastern Himalayas, evodia is cultivated in China. The partially ripe fruit is gathered in late summer.

Part Used Fruit.

Constituents Evodia contains the alkaloids evodine, evodiamine, and rutaecarpine.

History & Folklore Evodia is listed in the *Divine Husbandman's Classic* (Shen'ong Bencaojing) of the 1st century CE.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Evodia has a marked warming effect on the body, helping to relieve headaches and a wide range of digestive problems. In Chinese herbal medicine, evodia is used mainly for abdominal pains, vomiting, diarrhea, headaches, and a weak pulse.

Research Chinese studies indicate that evodia is analgesic and reduces blood pressure.

⚠ Caution Use evodia only under professional supervision.

Fagopyrum esculentum (Polygonaceae) Buckwheat

Description Annual growing to about 20 in (50 cm). Has arrow-shaped leaves and clusters of white or pink 5-petaled flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Buckwheat is native to central and northern Asia, and is cultivated extensively in temperate regions, especially the U.S. It is harvested in summer.

Parts Used Leaves, flowers.

Constituents Buckwheat contains bioflavonoids, especially rutin, which is strongly antioxidant. Rutin strengthens the inner lining of blood vessels.

History & Folklore Buckwheat's French name, *blé Sarrasin*, alludes to its ancient Middle Eastern origins. The grain was either introduced to Europe

during the Crusades (11th and 12th centuries), or it was brought to Spain by the Arabs several centuries earlier.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Used for a wide range of circulatory problems, buckwheat is best taken as a tea or tablet, accompanied by vitamin C or lemon juice (*Citrus limon*, p. 85) to aid absorption. Buckwheat is used particularly to treat fragile capillaries (seen as small bruises with no apparent cause), but also helps strengthen varicose veins and heal chilblains. Often combined with linden flowers (*Tilia* spp., p. 276), buckwheat is a specific treatment for hemorrhage into the retina. Buckwheat is also commonly taken in combination with other herbs for high blood pressure.

Related Species Recent research has shown that the Chinese *F. dibotrys* and *F. cymosum* are immunostimulant. They are prescribed for chronic bronchitis, inflamed gallbladder, and pulmonary abscesses.

Cautions Interacts with blood-thinning medication. Do not take as a medicine if taking prescribed anticoagulants.

Self-help Uses High blood pressure & arteriosclerosis, p. 301; Poor circulation & high blood pressure, p. 319.

Feronia limonia (Rutaceae) Wood Apple

Description A spiny tree growing to 30 ft (9 m), it has feathery leaves, red flowers, and round whitish fruit the size of oranges.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to southern India, wood apple is cultivated in tropical Asia.

Parts Used Fruit, leaves.

Constituents The fruit contains fruit acids, vitamins, and minerals. The leaves contain tannins and a volatile oil.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Wood apple fruit is used mainly to stimulate the digestive system. In India, the fruit forms part of a paste applied to tone the breasts. The astringent leaves are used to treat indigestion, flatulence, diarrhea, dysentery (particularly in children), and hemorrhoids. It is traditionally thought to act as a male contraceptive, although there is limited research to support this.

Ferula assa-foetida (Apiaceae) Asafoetida, Devil's Dung

Description Perennial plant growing to about 6½ ft (2 m). Has a fleshy taproot, hollow stem, compound leaves, and many white flowers in umbels.